subjects, left Tibet on 31 January 1946 via Gyantse and Yatung. On 28 February he filed a lengthy report from Gangtok in which he commented on the handing over of the reply to the ‘big insect-small insect’ letter of 18 April 1945:

‘When I presented the finally approved text of the aide-memoire (cum appendix), both the Foreign Secretaries were present together, the first time for several weeks. Rai Sahib Sonam set it forth paragraph-by-paragraph, sentence-by-sentence, to the Clerical Foreign Secretary, who was new to the subject and genuinely anxious to learn. The lay Foreign Secretary, Surkhang Dzasa, started off, as usual, full of pep, taking copious notes in Tibetan round hand. Then he gradually sagged *(supposedly on opium)*, till he looked like death, a ghastly yellow. Then, after a little snooze, the exposition still proceeding, he recovered sufficiently to cock one eye open, and say to his Clerical colleague, “It is all just a repeat of last year”.

‘After that meeting, not one word was said to me anywhere about the matter *(McMahon Line)*, and there was not the slightest change in my social relations with the *Kashag* or anyone else, including the Sera representatives, who continued almost heartily friendly to the end.’

This continued to be, more or less, the situation in the North East Frontier Tract until 15 August 1947, when Britain, a depleted super power post World War II, was forced to give up its grip on the Indian subcontinent. Considering the long history of border disputes and the fact that the area was not under army jurisdiction, it’s not entirely surprising that the events of 1962 caught India unprepared. Palit was to say much later, ‘Frankly, at the time, four-fifths of the Indian Army didn’t know where the hell Tibet was.’